

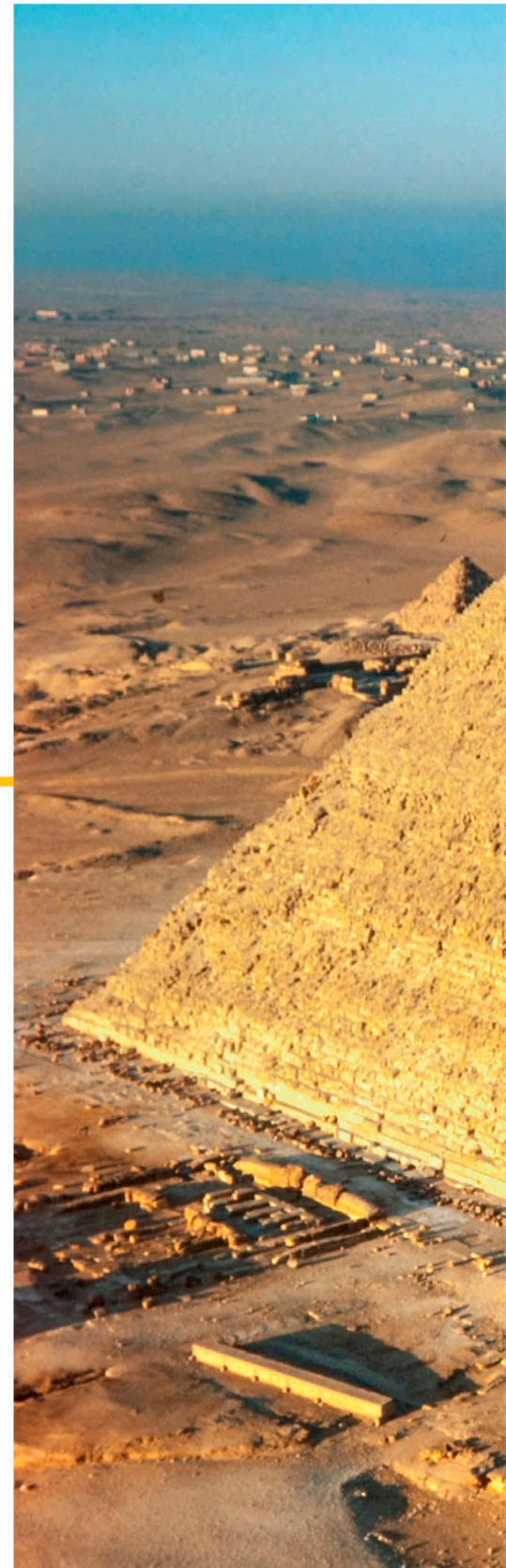
c. 2700–2200 BCE

THE AGE OF THE PYRAMIDS

The Old Kingdom of Egypt is often referred to as “The Age of the Pyramids”, because it encompasses the reigns of the great pyramid-building kings of the Third (2686–2613 BCE) to the Sixth (2345–2181 BCE) Dynasties. In the 500-year period from about 2700 BCE, architects developed the techniques to quarry limestone, transport huge quantities of the stone, and assemble the massive monuments that became symbolic of the majesty of ancient Egypt.

The first Egyptian pyramids appeared in the reign of King Djoser, in the Third Dynasty. Djoser moved his royal capital to

Memphis, and embarked upon a programme of building works to establish his court. This included the construction of a necropolis complex in nearby Saqqara overseen by his architect Imhotep, who is credited with the design of the first pyramid. The simple step pyramid at Saqqara inspired Djoser’s successors in the Fourth Dynasty, such as King Sneferu, to refine the design to create a true pyramid. Pyramid-building reached its high point with the construction of the great pyramids at Meidum and Dahshur, and the famous pyramid complex at Giza, built for kings Khufu, Khafre, and Menkaure.



KEY MOMENTS

27th century BCE Early step pyramids

The first Egyptian pyramids were tiered structures, built by adding successively smaller storeys of stone blocks onto a square or rectangular base. The model for these was Djoser’s Pyramid at Saqqara (*left*), which rose to a height of over 60 m (196 ft) in six steps.

26th century BCE First true pyramids

Architects of the Fourth Dynasty used much smaller steps to build a smoother pyramidal shape rising to a point, such as the Bent Pyramid of Dashur (*left*). The effect was further enhanced by cladding the structure with polished white limestone slabs.

26th century BCE The Sphinx

Alongside the Giza pyramid complex is another iconic ancient Egyptian structure, the Sphinx (*left*). Carved from the bedrock (but later restored with blocks of limestone), it is a colossal statue of the mythical cat-like sphinx, with the face of the then reigning King Khafre.